



Free bag of sweets



Pick up from WHSmith and TGJones today

Voucher
on page 44
Subject to availability.
Terms apply

COUNTY LINES GANGS SWITCH FROM DRUGS TO PHONE THEFTS

Police chief issues warning as street snatches soar — and urges tech firms to install ‘kill switch’ to make stolen devices useless

EXCLUSIVE

By **George Odling**
and **Miles Dilworth**

COUNTY-LINES gangs have turned from dealing drugs to snatching phones in a growing £70million-a-year epidemic.

Due to unprecedented overseas demand and softer sentences for those who are caught, vulnerable youngsters are being groomed to steal mobiles instead.

Stolen phones are being shipped abroad in bulk and sold around the world, a police chief warned, with 80 per cent of the 80,000 taken every year in London ending up overseas.

A Mail investigation tracked a phone snatched from an estate agent in Baker Street, central London, to a high-rise block in Hong Kong, where it ended up alongside hundreds of thousands of other handsets.

Commander James Conway, who oversees Scotland Yard's phone-theft investigations, said manufacturers and internet cloud providers

Turn to Page 2



Ordeal: Emily Damari lost two fingers after being shot by terrorists

EXCLUSIVE INTERVIEW

Hamas
kept me in
a cage like
an animal,
by British
hostage

PAGES 28-30